

Achievements and setbacks

Rachmaninoff was born near Novgorod into an aristocratic landowning family. His father gambled away his inherited wealth, and in 1882, after extensive estates had been sold to pay his debts, the family moved to a modest flat in St. Petersburg. Sergei showed musical talent, and rather than following family tradition by training for the military, in 1883, aged 10, he enrolled at the St. Petersburg Conservatory. Although gifted, Rachmaninoff was lazy and moody, and his progress was hampered by family turmoil—his parents had separated and one of his sisters died of diphtheria. In 1885, he failed his exams and transferred to the Moscow Conservatory. His most important teacher there was the renowned piano disciplinarian Nikolai Zverev, under whose strict but enlightened guidance he flourished. In 1892, aged 19, he graduated from the Conservatory with the rarely awarded Great Gold Medal, the highest possible student distinction.

Later that year, Rachmaninoff gave the premiere of his most famous solo piano piece, the dramatic and haunting Prelude in C-sharp minor. This work became so popular he is said to have regretted writing it, as he grew weary of having it requested as an encore every time he performed. In 1893, his first opera, *Aleko*, was successfully premiered at the Bolshoi Theater in Moscow and praised by Tchaikovsky. Still only 20, Rachmaninoff seemed to be launched on a brilliant career, but in 1897 he suffered a humiliating setback when the premiere of his Symphony No. 1